VALUES in crisis

HR's role in managing our changing societal values.

Society is a group of people living together sharing their feelings, their problems whether financial, social, economic or otherwise. Before becoming an engineer, a doctor, an advocate, a good businessman or a good professional, it is necessary to be a good human being, because no one can perform their jobs perfectly till they have human feelings and human values. Human values touch upon every aspect of our lives. They affect the different aspects of society in different ways, whether in politics, the economy, business, education, humanity, technology, ethical values, moral values or cultural values.

Whenever I used to contemplate about the "economic imbalance" in society, i.e. many are poor; whereas a few are rich, it always occurred to me that lack of human values is the fundamental problem. Human values are essential in each and every part of our lives, whether it is business, moral, social, physical and psychological.

Social values are ideas which help an individual to discriminate whether a particular object or behavior is good or bad, desirable or undesirable. There are rules which govern actions which are known as "Norms". People are expected to behave in accordance with the values held by the individual and according to the expected behavior which is known as "normative behavior".

In a broad sense, value may be considered as an attitude-related attribute that is projected upon people, objects and situations. Since values, sometimes gives orientation or striving towards a given goal, they can be viewed as motives.

Societal values can change over time due to a variety of factors, such as changes in cultural norms, technological advancements, shifts in political and economic systems, and demographic changes. These changes can have a significant impact on various aspects of society, including education, employment, social norms, and personal relationships.

For example, in recent years, there has been a growing emphasis on the importance of diversity, equity and inclusion in many societies. This has led to changes in policies and practices in areas such as hiring practices, educational curricula and social attitudes towards marginalized communities.

Similarly, the rise of social media and the internet has transformed the way people communicate and connect with each other. This, also, has led to changes in the way people form and maintain relationships, as well as the way information is shared and consumed.

Overall, changes in societal values can have both positive and negative effects, and it is important for individuals and communities to stay informed and engaged in discussions about these changes in order to shape the direction of society in a positive way.

INFLUENCE OF TECHNOLOGY

Technology has had a significant impact on societal values over the years. Here are some ways in which technology has influenced and changed societal values:

COMMUNICATION: Technology has made communication easier and faster than ever before. With the advent of social media and messaging apps, people can now connect with each other instantly, regardless of their location. This has changed the way we communicate and has made us more reliant on technology for communication.

PRIVACY: Technology has made it easier for people to share personal information online, leading to concerns about privacy. People now have to be more cautious about what they share online and who they share it with. This has led to a shift in societal values around privacy and security.

WORK-LIFE BALANCE: Technology has enabled people to work remotely and be more flexible with their schedules. This has led to a shift in societal values around work-life balance, with more people prioritizing their personal life over their work.

EDUCATION: Technology has made education more accessible than ever before. Online courses, e-books, and educational apps have

FROM EGYPT



BY PROF. DR M AMR SADIK
VP Dimensions Consulting Ltd. UK

made it easier for people to learn new skills and pursue their interests. This has led to a shift in societal values around education, with more people valuing lifelong learning and personal development.

ENTERTAINMENT: Technology has changed the way we consume entertainment. With streaming services and social media, people now have access to an endless supply of entertainment options. This has led to a shift in societal values around entertainment, with more people prioritizing instant gratification and constant stimulation.

Overall, technology has had a significant impact on societal values. It has changed the way we communicate, work, learn and entertain ourselves, leading to a shift in societal values around these areas. As technology continues to evolve, it will undoubtedly continue to shape and influence societal values in new and unexpected ways.

Changing social norms, values and ethics is a complex and ongoing process that can have a profound impact on society. Social norms refer to the unwritten rules of behavior that are accepted by members of a particular group or society. Values are the beliefs and attitudes that guide individuals' behavior, and ethics refer to the principles and standards of conduct that govern the behavior of individuals and groups.

Changing social norms, values, and ethics can occur through a variety of means, such as through education, social movements, media influence, changes in laws and policie, and shifts in cultural attitudes.

Some examples of social norms that have changed over time include attitudes towards gender roles, race relations and rights.

Changing values and ethics can also have significant impact on society. For example, shifts in attitudes towards environmentalism and sustainability have led to changes in the way that individuals and companies approach issues related to climate change and resource conservation.

Overall, changing social norms, values and ethics is an ongoing process that can have a profound impact on society. It requires a combination of education, advocacy and policy changes to create lasting change.

INFLUENCE OF EDUCATION

Education has a significant impact on societal values as it helps to shape individuals' perspectives, beliefs and attitudes towards various aspects of life. Here are some ways in which education can influence society values:

ENCOURAGING CRITICAL THINKING: Education encourages individuals to think critically and make informed decisions. This can help them to develop values such as rationality, logic and objectivity, which can help them make better decisions and evaluate various issues and topics objectively.

PROMOTING TOLERANCE AND EMPATHY: Education can help individuals to understand and appreciate diversity, and it can promote values such as tolerance, respect, and empathy towards others who are different from them.

FOSTERING SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY: Education can instill values such as responsibility, accountability, and civic duty in individuals. This can encourage them to become more socially responsible and active in their communities, which can contribute to the development of positive societal values.

Shaping cultural norms: Education can play a crucial role in shaping cultural norms and values. For example, education can help to promote values such as gender equality, environmental sustainability, and social justice, which can contribute to positive societal change.

Overall, education can have a profound impact on societal values, and it is essential to ensure that education is accessible and equitable to all members of society. By promoting positive values and encouraging critical thinking, education can help individuals to make informed decisions and contribute to a more just and equitable society.

INFLUENCE OF VALUES

Values in organizations refer to the guiding principles or beliefs that shape the behavior and decision-making of individuals within the organization. These values are intended to guide the behaviour of employees towards achieving the organization's goals and objectives, and are typically communicated through the organization's mission statement, vision statement, and core values.

Values can have a significant impact on the company's culture, as they help to shape the norms and expectations for behavior within the organization. When values are clearly defined and consistently reinforced, they can foster a sense of community and commitment among employees, and help to align the actions of individuals with the overall goals of the organization.

Examples of values that organizations may hold include integrity, accountability, teamwork, innovation, customer focus, and social responsibility. The specific values that are most important to a particular organization will depend on its industry, mission, and culture. Overall, values are a key component of organizational culture, and can help to create a sense of identity and purpose for employees, while also guiding their behavior towards achieving the organization's goals.

To this end, HR plays a vital role in making sure the organization is living its purpose and values. They can articulate and role-model desired individual mindsets and behaviors linked to purpose by identifying "moments that matter" in the company's culture and translating purpose into a set of leadership and employee norms and behaviors. ■

PROF. DR M AMR SADIK is VP Dimensions Consulting Ltd. UK, based in Cairo, Egypt. He is an HBR Advisory Council Member, Adjunct Professor IPE Management School, Paris, and of Middle East Programs for, Victoria University, School of Management, Switzerland and HR Professor and Board Member GUEST, Latvia

